

a soft prologue

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a soft prologue

by [Iriascend](#)

Summary

Tim decides to express his love through spreadsheets.
It doesn't go as planned, but it goes as it's supposed to.

Notes

Tim: sees Jason's soulmark
Tim: Oh. *Oh*.
Tim: it's *spreadsheet time*

Do I know what I'm doing or what's the point of this fic? No. It's fluff and attempted comedy. Have fun. I did.

Inspired by a campfire session on Capes & Coffee discord server, particularly by Leo's musings. I have written this all in less than 24h so like, ͇_(`ʘ)_/

Title is a play on "we deserve a soft epilogue" from "Seventy Years of Sleep #4", a Stevebucky poem by Nikka Ursula / cardiamachina

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

Chapter 1

Tim's obsession begins when he sees Robin do the famed Grayson quadruple somersault and figures out his and Batman's identity. It's already in full swing when Dick Grayson goes out into the night as Nightwing instead, but it doesn't reach its full potential until Tim lays his eyes on the next Robin a few months later.

He's... he's never thought he'd say that about another boy, but Jason Todd is just... *something else*. Tim can't quite pinpoint what makes him so deeply awestruck with him, even more than with Dick, but he knows he wants to take many, *many* pictures of the new Robin.

That is exactly why he nearly chokes on his breakfast granola bar when he catches a glimpse of the front page of Gotham Gazette on his way to school.

Soulmark Slip!!

Who is the fated lover of Bruce Wayne's new ward?

He immediately buys the newspaper and carefully looks closer at the slightly blurry photo in the center of the page.

A photo of Jason's lower back, exposed when his shirt rode up during yesterday's gala, apparently.
A photo of Jason's soulmark.

A photo of *Tim's* soulmark.

Staring at the picture, he starts rolling up the sleeve of his school uniform to compare it with his own forearm. Just in case he's remembering the most important mark on his body wrong. Or is hallucinating. Or delirious.

He stops himself halfway, looking up at the kiosk clerk watching him carefully with a suspicious gaze.

"Would be nice to have a Wayne as a soulmate, huh?" the woman asks, trying to sound friendly. Tim lets out a high-pitched, panicked gasp and runs down the alley before the stranger can memorize his face or the name of his school, embroidered at the front of his blazer. It'd be a *disaster* if this revelation he just had leaked to the press, too.

Vicki Vale's article is *not* how he wants to confess to Jason Todd.

But how *does he* want to confess? He's not sure. But darn does this explain a lot. Like why he's been so fixated on Robin. He didn't even think boys *can* be each other's soulmates!

His parents are going to be *so pissed* about it, though. They wanted him to have a kid with a girl from a good family and carry on the Drake name. Tim's pretty sure that's not going to happen if he's going to get together with Jason.

Because he's going to, right? He'll confess, Jason will like him and their parents will let them date.

... right? Jason's Bruce Wayne's kid. Not a legally adopted one (yet?), but it's still prestigious, Tim thinks. Maybe that'll be enough?

Speaking of which, will *mister Wayne* be okay with it? Is Tim good enough for his son? *For Robin???*

So many questions and Tim can't figure out an answer to any of them.

Tim shakes his head, it suddenly too full and too chaotic to think straight. He wants to scream. He wants to hide. He needs to clear his mind.

He takes a sharp turn towards the city park. Tim doesn't want to skip school but knows he wouldn't learn anything today anyway. The only thing he can think about is figuring out how to make it work.

How to court Jason Todd.

It takes him a week to answer that, and every other question. A week of research and compiling data and materials. A week of barely eating and hardly sleeping from stress and the sheer amount of *work* he has to do. A week of revising, refining, repeating over and over again to memorize it all perfectly.

But by the end of it, he has everything wrapped and ready, all I's dotted and all T's crossed. The giant presentation board detailing why he is a worthy soulmate for Jason Peter Todd is honestly a work of art. All the data is also printed and neatly bound, as well as saved on a USB stick in the form of photocopies and spreadsheets, for later revision if anyone's so inclined.

He even has all the documentation to back up his claims! A copy of his birth certificate and school ID, to confirm he really is Timothy Jackson Drake, and a high-quality photo of his soulmark, so they can make sure it's really a match; a rundown of Drake Industries current business partners and stock situation, to show he's a suitable match for a Wayne; a report card with his GPA, as well as his language tests results, both stamped by the school, so they know he's really smart and educated; recommendation letters from his martial arts instructor, music teacher and nanny, to vet for his stellar personality, too (those were kind of awkward to ask for, but Tim would do *anything* for his soulmate).

A reverse version of that — a document detailing why Jason Todd is a very good candidate for Timothy Drake, though without most of the confirming documentation (maybe he'll be able to get some once the Waynes accept him?) — is saved on his laptop, awaiting his parents' next return visit. It's not that *he* has any issues with Jason (Tim personally thinks he's amazing, thank you very much, regardless of whenever they're soulmates or not), but he knows he'll have to prove his soulmate's worth to his parents.

All in all, he's truly proud of himself.

He stretches and decides to reward himself with a soda (maybe even his favourite grape Zesti, as a treat!) and an evening photo run across Gotham. Working so hard, he didn't have time or energy to go out there and snap a picture of Robin lately. He kind of misses the thrill.

Therefore, Tim grabs his camera, a warm hoodie and his wallet, and sets out into the night.

It's a bad idea.

Tim is 12 years old and relatively small for his age. Usually, he is lucky enough to not get in trouble when he is alone in a dark alley, far from home and anyone that could help him.

But today is different.

He knows by far too well that all his martial arts training can go to hell in a situation like this. He should, reasonably, give the mugger anything he asks for without hesitation. The expensive camera hanging on his neck isn't worth his life.

But the photos of Gotham heroes inside it... might just be.

Time to prove he's worthy of Robin, it seems.

He takes one good look at the man in front of him, assessing the situation. He has a knife, but no gun, so if Tim gets far enough, everything should be... okay. Therefore he screams at the top of his

lungs — on the off chance someone is around and cares to check on a screaming kid in the middle of the night — then takes a plunge over the fire escape railing.

The plan is to land in the open dumpster underneath. Hopefully, all of his limbs will survive the fall intact, and he'll be able to climb out and make a beeline towards the nearby metro station before the mugger can run down the stairs. Once there, it should be easy to get lost in the crowd, hide in a nook or hop onto a train for safety.

The problem is, the man grabs Tim by the neck of his hoodie and nothing of that happens.

So Tim does the next best thing he can think of: throws his camera against the wall of the opposite building as hard as he can. It shatters, then falls two stories down to become a heap of unusable scrap.

At least the secret is safe, right?

The man curses, throwing Tim back against the brick wall with ease. "You just lost your ticket to life, kid," he hisses out, twirling his knife.

"My parents are rich! They own Drake Industries!" Tim cries out in panic, eyes glued to the blade that's slowly making its way towards his belly.

The man hesitates, so Tim fishes out his wallet out of his pocket and nearly shoves it at him. Upon seeing the photo ID of a high-society middle school inside of it, in fact, signed with the name Drake, the thug grins.

Tim hopes the heroes won't take too long to save him.

It takes them 13 hours. It's the longest 13 hours in Tim's life.

When his parents don't pick up (obviously), the thugs that kidnapped him call his school. That's probably how it leaks into the news, and how Batman and Robin pick up his trail.

Tim's a very good hostage. He's not doing anything fishy and doesn't even bother the men by asking for food, water or bathroom breaks. Honestly, with only a single can of Zesti in him, it's not like he needs the latter very much. He is a bit hungry at the beginning (he's been planning on grabbing a snack on his way back after the photo run), but that feeling fades quickly.

After a few hours, everything fades, really. Eventually, Tim zones out so hard he barely registers any of his surroundings.

Maybe that's how he gets all the bruises. They probably ask him questions and get angry when he doesn't respond. Tim's not sure. His brain is on vacation, and he's grateful for that because otherwise, he'd have to feel the black eye he's sporting.

Tim's mind clocks back in to work — although barely — only when he hears a concerned voice right by his ear. Someone pulls the blindfold off of his face, and gently touches his cheek.

"Hey there, are you okay? Can you hear me?"

He blinks a couple of times, trying to focus his eyes, then blushes hard and bites his chapped lip as he realizes who's talking to him.

Jason Todd is even prettier up close, and Tim's heartbeat speeds up. He's so lucky to be the soulmate of someone like that. He can't see Jason's eyes behind his mask, but he bets they're gorgeous. The way he speaks to Tim is so caring and tender. Tim never realised before how fluffy Jason's hair is and now he can't help but to reach out and put his grubby fingers in it.

Robin doesn't seem remotely fazed by any of that. He waves his hand in front of Tim's face, then reaches up to his earpiece. "B, I think he's in shock—"

"I love you."

The vigilante in front of him stops in his tracks, utterly confused, a frown on his face. "What the fuck?"

Tim scrambles to lift his sleeve enough to show him his soulmark. Jason loses a single beat and then looks back up at Tim.

"Why are you showing this to me?" he asks, badly trying to hide the excitement shining in his voice.

"I couldn't wait! You're amazing. I know who you are. I saw the newspaper."

"You are definitely in shock, kid. Let me—"

"I'm not a kid! I'm only 2 years younger than you," Tim interrupts him, then begins looking around for his presentation board. He'll explain! Everything is in there, including how mature he is for his age and how Jason doesn't need to worry and—

Then he realises the presentation is not there, the documents and the printouts are not there and he just messed up his only chance for a great first impression. He messed up his chance to properly court his amazing soulmate and now his parents will never let them be together, Batman will not let them be together.

Tears well up in his eyes and he's suddenly very, very tired again.

"I promise I'm good enough. I have this whole- everything prepared, it's just- not here. I'm going to do better. I promise. Don't tell them, my parents will be angry. I promise I'm good—"

Robin stays silent for a moment, then sighs very sadly. "Calm down, buddy. We can talk when you feel a bit better, okay?"

Tim nods and lets Jason cradle him in his arms.

"Please let me love you," he mumbles as his brain prepares for another brief holiday. Robin's embrace gets just a little bit tighter.

He doesn't know how he gets to the clinic. The time he spends in the ER is a blur. Tim can only say he really comes to when he's laying in a hospital bed and a nurse wakes him up for breakfast.

Though he's hungry, Tim's very much not in the mood to eat, so he just lazily stabs the bowl of cereal with his spoon, stewing in his misery. He will never get to properly know his wonderful soulmate, to see him smile and learn what his favourite flavour of soda is.

“Not a fan of hospital food, huh? Me neither. It tastes horrible. Want some fruit instead?”

Tim looks up, startled, trying to locate the source of the voice. Jason Todd is standing in the open doorway holding a “get better soon” kind of fruit basket, and Bruce Wayne is right behind him.

“We need to talk, young lad,” the man says sternly. Tim curls upon himself by instinct. Batman is probably angry he tried to woo Robin without asking him for permission first, or because he could’ve revealed Jason’s civilian identity, or maybe because Tim is just not worthy of a hero.

“Give him a break, B. He was kidnapped!” Jason walks up and sits on the side of the bed energetically. “I’m Jason. We’re neighbours. I heard what happened. Your parents are out of town, right? Didn’t want you to be alone after something like this, so I got Bruce to let me visit you. Do you like peaches? These are really good.”

He looks up hesitantly. “Actually, I... prefer apples. Peaches are fuzzy and, um, it feels funny in my mouth.”

“That’s fair.” Jason fishes an apple out of the basket. “I like strawberries best, but they’re out of season,” he adds, cutting the apple up into quarters with his pocket knife, then offers a piece to Tim.

When Tim reaches out to take it, Jason gasps loudly and grabs onto Tim’s forearm. “Is this your soulmark?!” he asks over-dramatically, then looks back to his foster father. It’s obvious for Tim that this is rehearsed, over-done on purpose, but he doesn’t understand what for. “B, look at this! We’re soulmates!”

Bruce Wayne sighs and approaches them, but contrary to Tim’s expectations, his expression is kind instead of stern. “It appears so,” he says gently.

"What are the chances, huh?" Jason grins at Tim. "I'm glad we ran into each other!"

It all throws Tim off. "You're not mad about it?" he asks quietly, daring to peek at Bruce, then at Jason. "Disappointed?"

"Why would we be?" Bruce looks genuinely shocked by the question.

"I'm... I got everything wrong. I wanted to make such a good impression... I had this great Powerpoint presentation with everything detailed but then I got myself kidnapped and beaten up and how can Jason like me if he sees me like *this*?" He gestures to his still bruised and swollen eye. "You're so great and I don't even have a courting gift—"

There's silence for a moment. Then Jason bursts into hysterical laughter.

Tim can understand the reaction — he feels laughable at the moment — but is honestly still kind of offended. “I tried,” he whispers. “Please give me a chance.”

“Oh my god,” Jason manages to utter when he catches a breath, “Did you make spreadsheets too?”

“... yeah?” Tim looks between them, confused. Only then he notices that Bruce Wayne is trying very hard to hide his amusement. “...is that bad?”

“Damn, B is going to love you,” Jason says, trying to calm down his breathing, but the giggles are not quite ready to leave him. “I think I’m going to get along with you too, you absolute fucking

nerd.”

It sounds like praise, so Tim perks up a bit, hopeful.

“And when you get better, we can talk about what you were doing out at night, hm?” Bruce Wayne throws in casually. “Maybe you can tell me about Robin? I heard he’s the one who rescued you.”

Tim gulps. Enamoured with Jason, he forgot that in his exhausted delirium he told them he knows their identities.

But regardless of everything, he seems to have made a good impression, and that’s all that matters.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

You ever illustrate your own fic 3 years after writing it? Asking for a friend.

Why you should let me marry Jason Todd

an analysis by Timothy Drake

barely
holding it
together

amused
to no end

barely
holding in
laughter



(originally posted on [Twitter](#))

End Notes

If you wanna say hi or talk with me, you can find me over on [Tumblr](#) :)

This story is part of the [LLF Comment Project](#), which was created to improve communication between readers and authors. This author invites and appreciates feedback, including:

- Short comments
- Long comments
- Questions
- “<3” as extra kudos
- Reader-reader interaction
- Minor spelling/typo correction

If you'd like to go the extra mile, try answering some of these questions in your comment:

- Did any particular sentence stand out to you? Do you have a favourite phrase from the fic, did you like the way something was worded?
- Did anything make you laugh?
- Has the fic caused an emotional reaction? Touched your heart, made you *feel*?
- Was there any particular scene that you liked?
- Have you noticed any recurring themes or motifs? Any Easter eggs?

This author sees and cherishes all comments, and tries to reply to them all, but may not manage to due to anxiety.

Please [drop by the Archive and comment](#) to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!